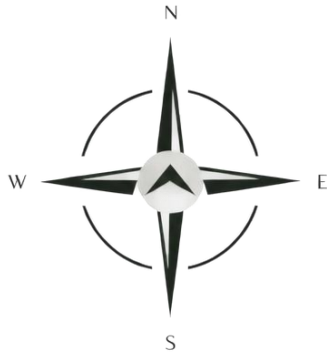




OUTBOUND

TRAVEL PLANNING • EST. 2026

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THE JAPAN GUIDE

A practical guide to planning a better trip

2026 EDITION

OUTBOUND.

Travel planning, rethought.



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01 — JAPAN, DONE PROPERLY

Japan is one of those countries where the biggest challenge isn't finding things to do. It's deciding **what not to do**.

Tokyo alone could fill a week. Kyoto can easily occupy several days. Osaka has its own food, nightlife and neighbourhoods, while places such as Hiroshima, Nara, Hakone, Kanazawa and the Japanese Alps all offer completely different experiences.

Then there is the temptation to add Mount Fuji, a traditional ryokan, an onsen, a bullet train, a ski resort, a theme park, a food tour and a few extra cities because they happen to be on the same rail line.

You can build an incredible trip that way.



You can also build an itinerary where half your holiday is spent checking out of hotels and dragging luggage through train stations.

The best way to approach Japan is to think in terms of **contrasts**.

Tokyo gives you scale, technology, food and modern Japanese culture. Kyoto gives you temples, gardens, traditional architecture and centuries of history. Osaka gives you food, nightlife and a more relaxed urban atmosphere. Hiroshima gives you history and access to Miyajima. Hakone gives you mountains, hot springs and the possibility of seeing Mount Fuji. The Japanese Alps and regional destinations offer a slower, more traditional side of the country. The result is that a great Japan itinerary doesn't need to contain ten destinations.

It needs to contain **three or four experiences that feel genuinely different**.

For a first trip, the classic route is **Tokyo → Kyoto → Osaka**, with optional additions such as Hakone, Nara or Hiroshima depending on how much time you have.

That route works because the destinations complement each other rather than simply adding more of the same.

Japan is also unusually good for independent travel. The rail network is extensive, cities are generally easy to navigate and the country's infrastructure makes moving between major destinations relatively straightforward. Japan's official tourism organisation specifically highlights the Shinkansen, airport access, taxis, bicycles and luggage storage as key parts of getting around.

But easy transport creates its own problem. Because you *can* get somewhere quickly doesn't mean you should.

A two-hour Shinkansen journey still involves getting to the station, navigating the station, finding your platform, checking in and reaching your hotel at the other end.

The more destinations you add, the more invisible time disappears. Japan rewards travellers who **slow down enough to notice the details**.

A quiet neighbourhood in Tokyo can be as memorable as Shibuya Crossing. A small ramen shop can be more memorable than a famous restaurant. A traditional ryokan can be more valuable than another night in a major city. The point isn't to tick off Japan's most famous attractions. It's to experience the country properly.

OUTBOUND RULE: Don't confuse seeing Japan with travelling through Japan.

A strong itinerary should have enough structure to make the trip easy, but enough space for you to wander.

02 — BEFORE YOU GO

Japan is one of the easiest long-haul destinations to travel independently, but the trip becomes significantly smoother if you understand a few things before arriving.

WHEN TO GO

Japan is a year-round destination, but the experience changes dramatically with the seasons.

Spring is famous for cherry blossoms, but this is also one of the busiest and most expensive periods in popular destinations.



Summer brings warmth, humidity and festivals, while mountain and northern areas can provide an escape from the heat.

Autumn is one of the strongest periods for a first trip, with comfortable conditions and autumn foliage creating particularly impressive scenery.

Winter brings cold weather to much of the country but opens up skiing, snow, winter onsens and a completely different side of Japan.

Don't plan your entire trip around seeing cherry blossoms unless that is genuinely one of your priorities. Japan is excellent outside peak blossom season.

ENTRY REQUIREMENTS

Entry rules depend on your passport and can change, so check the current requirements before departure using Japan's official immigration and government information. Do not rely on an old travel blog for visa information.

For most travellers, the important thing is simply making sure your passport, entry permission and travel documentation are all in order before you fly.

MONEY

Japan is highly developed, but don't assume that every business operates exactly like home. Cards are widely accepted, particularly in hotels, department stores, major restaurants and larger businesses.

Cash remains useful for smaller restaurants, local shops, vending machines, temples and some smaller accommodation. Carry a small amount of yen rather than relying exclusively on cards.

IC TRANSPORT CARDS

An IC card can make everyday transport dramatically easier. Rather than buying individual tickets for every local journey, you can use an IC card on many trains, subways and buses, as well as at various shops and vending machines.

The exact availability and compatibility can change, so check the current arrangements for the cities you're visiting.

THE LANGUAGE BARRIER

You do not need to speak Japanese to travel around Japan. English signage is common in major transport hubs and tourist areas. Translation apps can be extremely useful for menus, small restaurants and more complicated situations. Learn a few basic phrases, but don't feel you need to become fluent before arriving.

What matters more is being **polite and observant**.

JAPANESE ETIQUETTE

Japan rewards travellers who pay attention. Keep your voice down on trains. Don't block doors or walkways. Queue properly. Avoid eating while walking in situations where it isn't customary. Follow signs and instructions at temples, shrines and other cultural sites. Take your shoes off where required. Don't photograph people or private spaces without permission. These aren't complicated rules.

They're mostly about recognising that you're travelling through someone else's home rather than moving through a theme park.

SHOES

You'll encounter places where shoes need to be removed. This is particularly common in traditional accommodation, certain restaurants, temples and some other buildings. Wear shoes that are easy to take on and off.

LUGGAGE

This deserves more thought than it gets. Japan's train stations can be enormous. You may encounter stairs, crowded platforms and long walks between train lines. A huge suitcase quickly becomes a burden. Travel light where possible.

Japan also has excellent luggage-forwarding services, which can be extremely useful when moving between cities. If you're staying somewhere for several nights, consider forwarding your larger luggage and travelling with a smaller bag.

FOOD

Don't arrive with a strict list of restaurants you must visit. Japan is one of the best countries in the world for spontaneous food discoveries. A small restaurant with ten seats can be a better experience than a famous restaurant with a six-month waiting list. Research a few places you genuinely care about, but leave room for discovery.

ACCOMMODATION

Japan offers everything from capsule hotels and hostels to business hotels, ryokan and luxury properties. Your accommodation should reflect the route. Don't spend your entire budget on a beautiful hotel if it means you need to spend an hour commuting every day. Location is often more valuable than an extra star rating.

THE BIGGEST PRE-TRIP MISTAKE

The biggest mistake is booking every day before understanding how Japan actually works. Book your international flights. Choose the broad route. Book important accommodation. Reserve genuinely high-demand experiences. Then leave some space.

OUTBOUND TIP: Japan is one of the rare countries where getting lost in a neighbourhood can genuinely be part of the itinerary.

Don't plan that out.

03 — BUILD YOUR ROUTE

Japan rewards good route planning because the country's transport system makes it incredibly easy to keep adding destinations. The classic mistake is assuming that because Tokyo, Kyoto and Osaka are connected by fast trains, you should automatically add Hiroshima, Kanazawa, Takayama, Hakone and Fuji as well.

You don't need to.

Start with your **core experience**.

THE CLASSIC JAPAN TRIANGLE



For a first-time visitor, the strongest foundation is:

Tokyo → Kyoto → Osaka

Tokyo gives you modern Japan. Kyoto gives you traditional Japan. Osaka gives you food and nightlife.

From there, you can add one or two carefully chosen experiences.

WHAT SHOULD YOU ADD?

Hakone works if you want an onsen experience and mountain scenery.

Nara works extremely well as a day trip from Kyoto or Osaka.

Hiroshima + Miyajima is worth considering if history and culture are important to you.

Mount Fuji makes sense if seeing Fuji is genuinely important.

Kanazawa is excellent if you want traditional architecture, gardens, food and a slower city.

Japanese Alps work particularly well for travellers who want nature and smaller towns.

The mistake is adding all of them.

HOW MANY BASES?

Trip length	Recommended major bases	OUTBOUND approach
5–7 days	2–3	Choose the essentials
8–10 days	3–4	Classic first trip
11–14 days	4–5	Add one regional experience
15–21 days	5–6	Explore beyond the classics
3+ weeks	6+	Slow regional travel

These are deliberately conservative. Japan's transport makes ambitious itineraries possible. It doesn't necessarily make them enjoyable.

THE THREE-NIGHT RULE

Three nights is a useful benchmark for major cities. Tokyo deserves at least three nights. Kyoto deserves at least three nights. Osaka can work in two or three. Smaller destinations can work with one or two nights when they're part of a logical route. The more complicated the journey, the more time you should give the destination.

THINK ONE-WAY

One of the best ways to reduce unnecessary travel is to avoid returning to the same place. If possible, consider flying into Tokyo and out of Osaka, or vice versa. That allows the route to move naturally in one direction.

Instead of:

Tokyo → Kyoto → Osaka → Tokyo

you can do:

Tokyo → Kyoto → Osaka → home

That final return journey can save a surprising amount of time.

DON'T BUILD A RAIL-PASS ITINERARY

A common mistake is deciding to buy a rail pass first and then trying to “get your money's worth”.

Build the itinerary first. Then calculate the actual transport cost. The national Japan Rail Pass is no longer the automatic bargain it once was, and individual tickets can make more sense depending on your route.

Japan Rail Pass pricing and ticket structures have changed significantly from the historic low-price era, so check the current official pricing before purchasing.

THE ROUTE TEST

Before adding a destination, ask:

What does it add? How long will it take to reach? Could I get a similar experience somewhere already on my route? Am I genuinely excited to go? Would removing it make the trip better?

That final question is the most useful.

OUTBOUND RULE: Build Japan as a journey, not a checklist.

A strong route should feel like it is **progressing**, not constantly resetting.

04 — TOKYO

Tokyo is enormous.

Trying to “see Tokyo” in three days is impossible. The better approach is to experience **three or four sides of the city** and accept that you'll leave plenty unexplored.

Tokyo is where traditional Japan, futuristic technology, fashion, food, nightlife and quiet residential neighbourhoods all exist within the same enormous urban system.

HOW LONG?

For a first visit, **four nights is a strong starting point**. Three nights can work. Five or six is easy to justify if you're particularly interested in food, shopping, nightlife, anime, gaming, design or Japanese culture.

SHIBUYA

Shibuya is the obvious introduction to modern Tokyo.

The crossing is worth seeing, but don't spend your entire visit standing there taking photographs. Explore the surrounding streets. Shops, restaurants, cafés, bars and smaller neighbourhoods provide a much better understanding of the area.

SHINJUKU

Shinjuku is another essential part of the Tokyo experience. Skyscrapers, restaurants, department stores, nightlife and the famous neon streets make it one of the city's most recognisable districts.

At night, the area feels completely different. Don't rush through it.

ASAKUSA

Asakusa provides a stronger connection with old Tokyo. **Senso-ji** and the surrounding streets make this one of the best places to experience the city's traditional side.

Go early if you want a quieter experience.

UENO

Ueno combines parks, museums, markets and older neighbourhoods. It works particularly well for travellers who want something beyond the major commercial districts.

HARAJUKU & OMOTESANDO

This is where fashion, youth culture and design become the focus. Explore the side streets rather than only visiting the famous main areas.

AKIHABARA

If you're interested in gaming, anime, electronics or Japanese pop culture, Akihabara can be fascinating. If none of those things interest you, don't force it into the itinerary simply because it's famous.

FOOD

Tokyo is one of the world's great food cities. Sushi is only the beginning. Ramen, yakitori, tempura, tonkatsu, soba, udon, curry and countless regional dishes deserve attention. One of the best things you can do is deliberately eat somewhere small.

Don't assume that a restaurant needs to be famous online to be good.

NIGHTLIFE

Tokyo's nightlife is spread across different neighbourhoods. Shinjuku is energetic. Shibuya is younger and more commercial. Smaller bars can provide a much more intimate experience.

Don't try to experience everything in one night.

A FOUR-DAY STRUCTURE

Day 1: Arrive, explore your neighbourhood and experience Shibuya.

Day 2: Asakusa, Ueno and older Tokyo.

Day 3: Harajuku, Omotesando, Shibuya and Shinjuku.

Day 4: Food, shopping and whichever neighbourhood interests you most.

Day 5: Depart.

This gives you enough structure without turning Tokyo into a race.

WHERE TO STAY

Location matters enormously.

Areas around **Shinjuku, Shibuya, Ueno, Asakusa and Tokyo Station** can all work.

The best choice depends on what you care about. If nightlife matters, Shinjuku or Shibuya make sense. If you want traditional atmosphere, Asakusa is attractive. If transport convenience matters most, staying close to a major station can be extremely useful.

OUTBOUND VERDICT: Don't try to conquer Tokyo. Choose a few neighbourhoods and experience them properly.

The best Tokyo day may be the one where you have **nothing booked after lunch**.

05 — KYOTO & NARA

Kyoto is the part of Japan where you should slow down.

The city was the imperial capital for centuries and remains one of the country's strongest destinations for temples, gardens, traditional architecture, food and cultural experiences. Japan's official tourism organisation also warns that popular parts of Kyoto can experience significant visitor concentration, and recommends checking congestion information and exploring beyond the most crowded areas.

HOW LONG?

Give Kyoto **three nights at minimum**. Four nights is better if traditional Japan is a major priority. Five can easily be justified if you want to explore beyond central Kyoto.

HIGASHIYAMA

This is one of the classic Kyoto areas. Traditional streets, temples and historic architecture make it one of the most atmospheric parts of the city.

The downside is obvious:

Everyone knows. Go early.

FUSHIMI INARI

The famous red torii gates are one of Kyoto's defining images. The site is much more enjoyable when you move beyond the busiest lower section. If you have time, walk further up the mountain.

KINKAKU-JI

The Golden Pavilion is one of Kyoto's most famous attractions. It is beautiful. It is also crowded. Treat it as one stop rather than spending half a day trying to photograph it from every angle.

ARASHIYAMA

Arashiyama is famous for its bamboo grove, but there is much more to the area. Explore the temples, river and surrounding streets rather than arriving, photographing the bamboo and immediately leaving.

Again, early morning can make a significant difference.

GION

Gion is one of Kyoto's most recognisable historic areas. Treat it respectfully. Do not photograph geisha or maiko where photography is prohibited, and don't follow or obstruct people simply because you're trying to get a photograph.

You are walking through a living neighbourhood.

FOOD

Kyoto has an enormous food culture. Kaiseki, tofu cuisine, tea, sweets and traditional Japanese dishes are all part of the city's identity.

You don't need to spend huge amounts of money to experience good food.

NARA

Nara is one of the easiest additions to a Kyoto itinerary. It can work as a day trip rather than requiring another hotel change. The city's temples, parks and deer make it very different from Kyoto while remaining relatively easy to reach.

If your trip is already packed, however, Nara should be considered optional.

KYOTO'S BIGGEST MISTAKE

Trying to visit the city's famous attractions at the same time as everyone else. Instead, build your days around geography. Choose one part of the city and explore several things nearby.

Don't spend two hours crossing Kyoto simply to visit one temple.

THE BETTER KYOTO DAY

Start early. Visit one major attraction before the crowds. Have lunch somewhere local. Spend the afternoon exploring a quieter neighbourhood or garden. Have dinner. Then walk through the city after dark. That rhythm is far better than eight hours of sightseeing.

OUTBOUND RULE: Kyoto is not a checklist of temples.

It's an atmosphere. Give yourself time to experience it.

06 — OSAKA, HIROSHIMA & THE WEST

Osaka is often treated as the final stop between Kyoto and the airport. That's a mistake. Osaka has its own identity, particularly around **food, nightlife and local culture**.

It is less formal than Kyoto and often feels more relaxed.

OSAKA

Give Osaka **two or three nights**.

DOTONBORI

Dotonbori is the obvious starting point. Neon, restaurants, street food and crowds make it one of the city's defining areas.

Visit at night when the area is at its most atmospheric.

OSAKA FOOD

Osaka is famous for its food culture. Try **takoyaki, okonomiyaki, kushikatsu and local noodle dishes**. Don't eat only in Dotonbori.

Explore smaller neighbourhoods as well.

UMEDA

Umeda provides a more modern side of Osaka. Skyscrapers, shopping, restaurants and major transport connections make it useful both as a destination and a base.

OSAKA CASTLE

Osaka Castle is one of the city's major landmarks. It is worth seeing, but don't allow it to dominate the itinerary. Osaka's food and neighbourhoods are arguably more distinctive than its individual sightseeing attractions.

UNIVERSAL STUDIOS JAPAN

If you're a theme-park fan, Universal Studios Japan can justify a full day. If you aren't, don't spend a valuable Japan day there simply because everyone else recommends it.

HIROSHIMA

Hiroshima adds an entirely different dimension to the trip. The **Peace Memorial Park and Atomic Bomb Dome** provide a place for reflection and understanding rather than simple sightseeing.

Approach the experience respectfully. Hiroshima is not just a historical stop. The city itself has food, neighbourhoods and a distinct identity.

MIYAJIMA

Miyajima is one of the strongest additions to a western Japan itinerary. The island's famous torii gate, temples, mountain scenery and coastal setting make it a very different experience from the major cities.



You can visit as a day trip from Hiroshima or stay overnight if you want a slower experience.

OSAKA OR HIROSHIMA?

If you have limited time, this becomes a genuine decision.

Choose Osaka if food, nightlife and urban Japan are the priority. **Choose Hiroshima** if history, culture and Miyajima appeal more.

If you have two weeks, you can comfortably include both.

THE WESTERN JAPAN ROUTE

A strong route is:

Kyoto → Hiroshima → Osaka

This keeps the journey logical rather than requiring unnecessary backtracking.

Alternatively:

Kyoto → Osaka → Hiroshima → Osaka

works if Osaka is your departure point.

OUTBOUND VERDICT: Osaka is not simply “another Tokyo”. It is the place to **eat, drink and relax** after the intensity of the capital and the cultural focus of Kyoto.

07 — MOUNT FUJI, HAKONE & THE JAPANESE ALPS

Japan's mountain regions provide the contrast that can turn a city-heavy itinerary into a much more complete trip.

The key is choosing **one mountain experience**, rather than trying to fit all of them in.

HAKONE

Hakone is one of the easiest additions to a Tokyo itinerary. The area is known for hot springs, mountain scenery, traditional accommodation and views towards Mount Fuji when conditions cooperate. The phrase “when conditions cooperate” matters. Don't build your entire trip around seeing Fuji from one specific viewpoint. Weather can change quickly.

RYOKAN

One of the best reasons to visit Hakone is staying in a **ryokan**. A traditional Japanese inn can provide a completely different accommodation experience from a Tokyo hotel. Tatami rooms, Japanese meals and onsen can become the experience itself. This is one place where spending more money can genuinely change the trip.



MOUNT FUJI

Mount Fuji is Japan's defining mountain. But there is a difference between **seeing Fuji and climbing Fuji**. If you simply want to see the mountain, build flexibility into your itinerary.

If you want to climb it, treat the climb as a serious hiking experience and plan around the official climbing season, routes, weather and current regulations. Do not treat it as a casual day trip.

KAWAGUCHIKO

The Fuji Five Lakes area provides some of the most recognisable views of Mount Fuji. It can be a strong alternative to Hakone if your main objective is photography and mountain views. But again, visibility is never guaranteed.

THE JAPANESE ALPS

If you have more time, the Japanese Alps provide an entirely different side of the country. Places such as **Takayama, Kanazawa and the surrounding mountain areas** offer traditional architecture, regional food and slower travel.

Japan's official tourism organisation specifically highlights Takayama and Kanazawa alongside the country's mountain and cultural destinations.

KANAZAWA

Kanazawa is particularly strong for travellers interested in traditional Japan without the scale and crowds of Kyoto. Gardens, historic districts, crafts, seafood and traditional architecture make it an excellent addition to a longer itinerary.

TAKAYAMA

Takayama works particularly well for travellers who want mountain scenery, traditional streets and a smaller-town experience. It becomes more attractive when you have at least two weeks.

WHICH ONE?

Have 7–10 days?

Choose Hakone or Fuji if you want a mountain experience.

Have 14 days?

You can consider Hakone, Fuji or one additional regional destination.

Have 21 days?

Now the Japanese Alps become much easier to justify.

OUTBOUND RULE: Don't add Fuji because you feel your Japan itinerary needs a mountain. Add it because **you actually want the mountain experience**.



08 — GETTING AROUND JAPAN

Japan's transport system is one of the country's greatest travel advantages. It is also one of the easiest places to overcomplicate.

SHINKANSEN

The Shinkansen is one of the defining Japanese travel experiences. Fast, comfortable and reliable, it makes travelling between major cities remarkably straightforward. The classic Tokyo → Kyoto → Osaka route is particularly easy by high-speed rail.

You do not need to turn every journey into a sightseeing experience. Sometimes the train is simply the most efficient way to move.

JAPAN RAIL PASS

Do not automatically buy the national Japan Rail Pass. The economics changed substantially when prices were increased.

Instead:

1. Build your route.
2. Calculate your major train journeys.
3. Compare the cost.
4. Then decide whether a pass makes sense.

The official JR Pass information should be checked before purchase because prices, products and conditions can change.

LOCAL TRAINS

Cities such as Tokyo and Osaka have extensive local rail and subway networks. Use them. Taxis can be convenient, but relying on taxis for every journey quickly becomes expensive.

IC CARDS

An IC card can make local travel much easier. Instead of buying individual tickets every time, you can tap in and out on compatible transport. They can also be useful for small purchases.

LUGGAGE

This is where experienced travellers have an advantage. Don't drag a giant suitcase across Japan if you don't need to. Use luggage-forwarding services when moving between major cities. Travel with a smaller overnight bag where possible. It makes stations, trains and hotels dramatically easier.

FLYING

Domestic flights can make sense when the distances become large. For example, if you're extending your trip to Hokkaido, Kyushu or Okinawa, flying can save enormous amounts of time. Don't become obsessed with trains simply because you're in Japan. Use whichever transport makes the route better.

BUSES

Buses become more important in rural and mountain areas where trains don't reach conveniently. Always check the timetable carefully.

TAXIS

Japanese taxis are generally reliable but can be expensive compared with trains. Use them strategically. A taxi from a station to a ryokan may be excellent value if it saves a complicated transfer with luggage.

THE TRANSPORT DAY

Don't make the mistake of looking only at the train duration. A “two-hour train journey” can become:

Hotel checkout → station → platform → train → station → local train → hotel check-in.

That's still a large part of your day. Count the entire journey.

BOOKING

Major train routes are usually straightforward, but if you're travelling during extremely busy periods or need specific reserved seats, book appropriately in advance.

Popular attractions, restaurants and experiences can have separate reservation systems. Don't leave everything until the day before.

THE GOLDEN RULE

Never build an itinerary where one delayed train destroys the rest of your holiday. Leave breathing room. Especially before international flights.

OUTBOUND TIP: Japan's transport network should make your trip easier, not encourage you to add more destinations.

09 — THE ROUTES

Japan is where itinerary planning can make an enormous difference. The following routes are designed around **arrival and departure days**.

So:

7 days = usually 6 nights.

10 days = usually 9 nights.

14 days = usually 13 nights.

21 days = usually 20 nights.

The objective is not to maximise destinations.



It is to create a route where every move adds something.

7 DAYS — THE ESSENTIALS

Seven days is short for Japan, but you can still have an excellent trip.

OPTION A — TOKYO + KYOTO

Days 1–3 — Tokyo

Three nights.

Experience modern Tokyo, food, neighbourhoods and nightlife.

Days 4–6 — Kyoto

Three nights.

Temples, traditional streets, food and culture.

Day 7 — Departure

This is the strongest seven-day route if it is your first time in Japan and you want the classic experience.

OPTION B — TOKYO + OSAKA/KYOTO

Three nights Tokyo.

Three nights around Kyoto or Osaka.

Day 7 departure.

Choose this if food and nightlife matter more than spending extensive time in Kyoto.

OPTION C — TOKYO + HAKONE + KYOTO

This can work if Mount Fuji/onsen is a major priority. But be careful. With only six nights, adding Hakone creates another hotel change.

I'd only choose it if the mountain/onsen experience is genuinely important.

WHAT NOT TO DO

Tokyo → Hakone → Kyoto → Nara → Osaka → Hiroshima in seven days.

That isn't a holiday. It's a rail timetable.

10 DAYS — THE OUTBOUND DEFAULT



Ten days is enough for the classic Japan experience.

OPTION A — TOKYO + KYOTO + OSAKA

Days 1–4 — Tokyo

Four nights.

Days 5–7 — Kyoto

Three nights.

Days 8–9 — Osaka

Two nights.

Day 10 — Departure

This is the simplest strong first-time route.

You experience:

modern Japan → traditional Japan → food/nightlife Japan.

OPTION B — TOKYO + HAKONE + KYOTO + OSAKA

Days 1–3 — Tokyo

Three nights.

Day 4 — Hakone

One night in a ryokan/onsen setting.

Days 5–7 — Kyoto

Three nights.

Days 8–9 — Osaka

Two nights.

Day 10 — Departure

This is better if the traditional ryokan/onsen experience is important to you.

OPTION C — TOKYO + KYOTO + HIROSHIMA

Four nights Tokyo. Three nights Kyoto. Two nights Hiroshima. Day 10 departure. This is particularly strong for travellers interested in history and culture.

OUTBOUND VERDICT: Ten days gives you enough time for **three or four major bases**. Don't make it six.



14 DAYS — THE CLASSIC JAPAN TRIP

Two weeks is where Japan starts to open up.

OPTION A — TOKYO + HAKONE + KYOTO + OSAKA + HIROSHIMA

Days 1–4 — Tokyo

Four nights.

Days 5–6 — Hakone

Two nights.

Days 7–9 — Kyoto

Three nights.

Days 10–11 — Osaka

Two nights.

Days 12–13 — Hiroshima

Two nights.

Day 14 — Departure

This is ambitious but workable.

The route gives you:

city → mountains → tradition → food → history.

OPTION B — TOKYO + KYOTO + OSAKA + HIROSHIMA

Days 1–4 — Tokyo

Four nights.

Days 5–8 — Kyoto

Four nights.

Days 9–10 — Osaka

Two nights.

Days 11–13 — Hiroshima/Miyajima

Three nights.

Day 14 — Departure

This is slower and, in my view, better for travellers who don't want constant hotel changes.

OPTION C — TOKYO + KYOTO + JAPANESE ALPS

Four nights Tokyo. Four nights Kyoto. Five nights across Kanazawa/Takayama or another carefully selected regional route. Day 14 departure.

Choose this if you want **traditional Japan and nature** rather than more major cities.

OUTBOUND RULE

Fourteen days doesn't mean you need to add everything.

It means you can finally give Japan's best destinations **the time they deserve**.

21 DAYS — JAPAN, PROPERLY

Three weeks allows you to move beyond the standard Golden Route.

A strong first-time route could be:

DAYS 1–5 — TOKYO

Five nights.

Explore different neighbourhoods rather than trying to see everything.

DAYS 6–7 — HAKONE / FUJI

Two nights.

Ryokan, onsen and mountain scenery.

DAYS 8–11 — KYOTO

Four nights.

Temples, gardens, food and traditional neighbourhoods.

DAYS 12–13 — NARA / OSAKA

Two nights around Osaka, with Nara as a day trip if desired.

DAYS 14–16 — HIROSHIMA & MIYAJIMA

Three nights.

History, culture and island scenery.

DAYS 17–20 — KANAZAWA / JAPANESE ALPS

Four nights.

Slow down and experience a more regional side of Japan.

DAY 21 — DEPARTURE

This route is deliberately broad. If you want more nature, extend the Alps. If food is the priority, give Osaka more time. If traditional Japan is your priority, extend Kyoto. If you're fascinated by Tokyo, simply stay longer there.

Three weeks should create **more breathing room**, not simply more destinations.

WHICH ROUTE IS RIGHT FOR YOU?

If you want the **classic first Japan trip**, choose:

Tokyo → Kyoto → Osaka.

If you want **culture and traditional Japan**, give more time to Kyoto and add Nara or Kanazawa.

If you want **food and nightlife**, prioritise Tokyo and Osaka.

If you want **mountains and onsens**, add Hakone or the Japanese Alps.

If you want **history**, add Hiroshima.

If you want **nature**, consider the Alps rather than another city.

If you want **anime, gaming and modern Japanese culture**, spend longer in Tokyo.

If you want **a slower trip**, remove destinations rather than adding more.

The strongest first-time Japan itinerary is usually not the most ambitious.

It's the one where every destination feels **deliberate**.

10 — YOUR FINAL JAPAN CHECKLIST

Japan is easy to travel around. That makes it dangerously easy to over-plan. Your final job is to make sure the itinerary works as an actual holiday.

BEFORE YOU BOOK

Decide what you want from Japan.

Food? Culture? Technology? History? Nature? Shopping? Nightlife? Onsen? Snow?



Choose your priorities. Then build the route around them. Don't start by listing every Japanese city you've heard of.

YOUR ROUTE

Check every transfer. Calculate the actual door-to-door journey. Make sure your hotel locations make sense. Avoid unnecessary backtracking. If possible, consider flying into Tokyo and home from Osaka, or the reverse.

YOUR TRAINS

Don't buy a rail pass automatically. Build the route first. Calculate the major journeys. Then compare the actual cost with the available rail passes and tickets. Check current official JR information before purchasing because pricing and conditions can change.

YOUR ACCOMMODATION

Book your important stays. If you want a ryokan, book it early. If you want an onsen experience, choose the experience rather than simply choosing the cheapest hotel with “onsen” in the description.

For cities, prioritise **location**. A slightly smaller hotel five minutes from the station can be far more useful than a larger hotel 30 minutes away.

YOUR FOOD

Choose a few restaurants you genuinely want to experience. Don't book every meal. Leave space for spontaneous discoveries. Japan is too good a food destination to spend the entire trip following a spreadsheet.

YOUR ETIQUETTE

Remember:

Keep trains quiet. Queue properly. Don't block walkways. Follow temple rules. Remove shoes when required. Respect photography restrictions. Don't treat residential areas as attractions. Japan's appeal partly comes from the fact that everyday life still exists around the tourism.

Protect that.

YOUR LUGGAGE

Pack light. Consider luggage forwarding between major destinations. Keep important belongings accessible. Use a smaller bag for overnight trips.

YOUR MONEY

Set a realistic daily budget. Japan can be surprisingly affordable in some areas, but accommodation, restaurants, attractions, taxis and experiences can quickly increase costs. Spend more on the experiences that matter.

Save on the things that don't.

YOUR THREE NON-NEGOTIABLES

Before you leave, identify the **three things you absolutely want to experience**.



Maybe:

Eat incredible sushi in Tokyo. Stay in a traditional ryokan. Explore Kyoto's temples at sunrise.

Or:

See Mount Fuji. Visit Hiroshima. Experience Osaka's food scene.

There is no correct list. Those three experiences should become the anchors around which everything else fits.

THE FINAL TEST

Look at the itinerary one last time.

Ask:

Am I excited about every destination? Have I allowed enough time in each place? Are the transfers realistic? Have I avoided unnecessary backtracking? Have I left any unplanned time? Does this actually feel like a holiday?

If the answer is no, remove something.

One less city. One extra night. One slower morning. One afternoon with no plan. Japan rewards curiosity. You don't need to see everything. You don't even need to see everything that is famous. You need to **pay attention**. The best Japan trip is not the one where you visit the most places. It is the one where you remember the small details: The ramen shop you found by accident. The quiet street behind the temple. The train ride through the mountains. The vending machine coffee. The ryokan dinner. The neon reflected in the rain. The view you weren't expecting.

OUTBOUND RULE: Don't leave Japan feeling like you completed a checklist.

Leave feeling like you **experienced a country**.

OUTBOUND.

Fewer places. Better trips.